

assigned to her ex-husband. Opal told the creditor that this was not her responsibility. Her ex-husband had been assigned that credit card in her divorce settlement and not her.

The creditor explained that she was equally responsible since it was a joint credit card in both of their names. Opal decided to agree to pay it since she didn't want to ruin her credit report. She remembered that the balance was not that high when she divorced and after a year there was probably not much left to repay. To her horror, her ex-husband had charged the credit card up to its \$10,000 limit.

Opal received several more of these calls that week from other creditors. It was always the same story. Her ex-husband had apparently charged up the credit cards to the limit with no intention of paying them off. In his bitterness, Paul purposely wanted to hurt Opal knowing that they would go after her for payment after they had given up trying to collect from him. In fact, Paul was currently unemployed. He knew, having once worked in a collection agency, that the creditors would always go for the deepest pocket. If one pocket is empty, they will go after the other. Opal eventually paid Paul's assigned debts, not wanting to hurt her credit since her name was still on the joint account.

Opal did not know she should have closed the joint accounts that had been assigned to Paul. That way, her ex-husband wouldn't have been able to increase the debt owed upon their divorce settlement. Since the accounts remained open, nothing stopped her ex-husband from charging more on the credit cards. If Opal had periodically looked at a copy of her credit report, she would have discovered that the balances were increasing. Sadly, Opal was never advised to do this. Opal learned the hard way that joint accounts are both parties' responsibility and creditors are not legally bound by any decisions made in court.

